

CS F364: Design & Analysis of Algorithms

Quiz 4 — June 11, 2026

Coverage: Lectures 1–14

Note

Instructions:

- Time: 15 minutes.
- Write your answers clearly on paper, scan, and upload to Google Classroom.
- Show all steps for full credit.

Question: Huffman Coding

A file contains characters with the following frequencies:

Character	A	B	C	D	E
Frequency	10	15	30	5	40

We want to design an optimal prefix code for these characters using Huffman's greedy algorithm.

(a) [3 marks] Construct the optimal Huffman tree. Draw the final tree, showing the character and frequency at each leaf node, and the sum of frequencies at each internal node. Show the key intermediate steps of tree construction.

(b) [1 mark] Write the resulting binary code for each character. Assume that left branches are labeled with 0 and right branches are labeled with 1 (or vice versa, specify which convention you used).

(c) [1 mark] Compute the expected (average) number of bits per character under this Huffman code. How does it compare to the number of bits required per character using a standard fixed-length binary code for 5 characters? (State the percentage of space saved).

Solution

Part (a) — Tree Construction Steps

1. **Initial Forest:** The priority queue sorted by frequency contains:

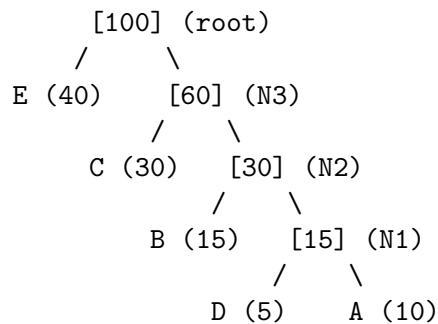
- $D : 5$
- $A : 10$
- $B : 15$
- $C : 30$
- $E : 40$

2. **Step 1:** Merge the two lowest frequencies, $D(5)$ and $A(10)$.

- Create parent node N_1 with weight $5 + 10 = 15$.

- The tree N_1 has children D and A .
 - Queue now contains: $B : 15, N_1 : 15, C : 30, E : 40$.
3. **Step 2:** Merge the two lowest, $B(15)$ and $N_1(15)$.
- Create parent node N_2 with weight $15 + 15 = 30$.
 - Queue now contains: $C : 30, N_2 : 30, E : 40$.
4. **Step 3:** Merge the two lowest, $C(30)$ and $N_2(30)$.
- Create parent node N_3 with weight $30 + 30 = 60$.
 - Queue now contains: $E : 40, N_3 : 60$.
5. **Step 4:** Merge the remaining two nodes, $E(40)$ and $N_3(60)$.
- Create the root node with weight $40 + 60 = 100$.

Final Huffman Tree Structure:



Part (b) — Binary Prefix Codes

Using the convention **Left Branch = 0**, **Right Branch = 1**:

- **E:** 0 (length 1)
- **C:** 10 (length 2)
- **B:** 110 (length 3)
- **D:** 1110 (length 4)
- **A:** 1111 (length 4)

(Note: If students used *Right Branch = 0* and *Left Branch = 1*, the codes will be symmetric (e.g. $E = 1$, $C = 01$, etc.) and are fully correct.)

Part (c) — Average Code Length & Space Savings

1. Average Bits per Character

$$\begin{aligned}
 \text{Average Length} &= \sum (\text{Probability} \times \text{Codeword Length}) \\
 &= \frac{10}{100}(4) + \frac{15}{100}(3) + \frac{30}{100}(2) + \frac{5}{100}(4) + \frac{40}{100}(1) \\
 &= 0.40 + 0.45 + 0.60 + 0.20 + 0.40 \\
 &= \mathbf{2.05} \text{ bits per character}
 \end{aligned}$$

2. Comparison to Fixed-Length Coding

- A standard fixed-length binary code representing 5 characters requires $\lceil \log_2 5 \rceil = \mathbf{3}$ bits per character (e.g., 000 to 100).
- Space saved per character = $3 - 2.05 = 0.95$ bits.
- Percentage savings:

$$\frac{3 - 2.05}{3} \times 100\% = \frac{0.95}{3} \times 100\% \approx \mathbf{31.67\%}$$